

The Lion and the Mouse

A lion lay sleeping beneath a broad tree after a long hunt. The shade was cool, and his breathing was deep and slow. A small mouse, hurrying home through the roots, ran across the lion's paw. The lion woke at once and trapped the mouse beneath one huge claw. To the mouse, the claw looked like a falling hill.

"Please let me go," squeaked the mouse. "One day I may be able to help you." The lion began to laugh. He could not imagine how such a tiny creature could ever assist the king of the animals. Still, the mouse's fear touched him, and the day was peaceful. He lifted his paw and let her run away. The mouse disappeared into the grass, grateful and determined not to forget the kindness.

Several weeks later, the lion followed the smell of prey into a clearing where hunters had placed a strong rope net. Before he saw it, the net dropped over him. He roared and struggled, but every movement pulled the knots tighter. The forest shook with the sound, yet none of the larger animals dared approach the hunters' trap.

The mouse heard the roar from her nest. She recognized the voice of the lion who had spared her. Following the sound, she found him caught in the ropes. "Be still," she said. "I have small teeth, but they are sharp." The lion stopped struggling. The mouse gnawed one knot, then another, then another. It was slow work, and the lion had to wait with patience he had rarely needed before. At last a gap opened wide enough for him to push through.

Free again, the lion thanked the mouse with a bowed head. He understood that strength comes in many forms. The mouse had not fought the net with force; she had used the ability she possessed and the loyalty she had chosen to give. From that day, the lion no longer judged a creature's value by its size. And the mouse, though still small, walked through the forest knowing that even a quiet act of kindness can return in an unexpected hour.